



MONTHLY UPDATE

Gambia: monthly update, July – August 2026

Edition of 2026-08-30 • 30 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH • GOVERNANCE • FINANCE • ICT INFRASTRUCTURE • DPI • TECHNOLOGY • CAPACITY • DATA

Summary of the month

Within nine days the country's identity spine, its sovereign hosting and its mobile network all changed state: the identity system and the state's first data centre entered service on 1 July, and [80% of the state mobile operator passed to a private buyer on 9 July](#). The second cluster is revenue administration — between 20 July and 4 August the Accountant General signed in a new collection platform, customs agreed a data-exchange roadmap with Senegal, and the finance ministry gave its fullest account yet of what digitalised collection has recovered.

Governance

Legislation and regulation

An Act already in force showed what passing one is worth on its own: the press union reported on 7 August that [most public institutions have yet to appoint the information officers the Access to Information Act requires, and that twenty-one-day requests go unanswered](#). No government response, compliance count or enforcement action is on record. The Communications Bill 2025, meanwhile, stayed in committee. Two Assembly committees [met the Press Union and the Media Council on 18 July 2026](#); the Union set out the media laws it wants repealed alongside the bill, and members said they could take stakeholder views into committee but not debate it publicly.

A second instrument was validated on [31 July 2026: the State Intelligence Service Bill](#), at a workshop attended by the National Security Adviser, the Chief of Defence Staff, the Assembly's defence committee and civil society. The Adviser said the draft prohibits torture, unlawful detention and political targeting, requires judicial warrants and oversight for intrusive measures, and gives the Assembly review of the Service's budgets. Its threat frame is cybercrime, espionage, disinformation and organised crime, so it is where Gambian communications interception would sit. The text is not held, the Bill has not been tabled, and it does not appear in the Assembly's bills library, checked 2026-08-08.

Data protection

The body that carries both of the country's information statutes surfaced in the record for the first time this window, and it surfaced as a recipient of support rather than as a regulator acting. The Information Commission, responsible for the Access to Information Act 2021 and the Personal Data Protection and Privacy Act 2025, is [receiving UNFPA-funded support under the Peacebuilding Fund's Public Accountability Project to build a communication strategy raising public awareness of both statutes](#). No budget, staffing, caseload or enforcement record for the commission is held, and awareness-raising support is not evidence of capacity to enforce.

Regional collaboration

The revenue authority [hosted the seventh ATAF Heads of Tax Administrations Master Class in Banjul on 23-24 July 2026](#). The Forum's executive secretary argued from Rwanda, Kenya and Morocco that digital systems deliver only alongside governance reform — "technology alone collects nothing" — and [pressed for a united African position at the United Nations](#).

The bilateral channel that bears on connectivity moved from signature to work. The June 2026 telecommunications and digital-economy memorandum with Senegal [went into implementation around four priorities — connectivity, cybersecurity, skills and digital transformation — with the Senegalese telecommunications and digital minister travelling to Banjul to agree the first joint work, the two regulators having separately deepened cooperation on frequency coordination, service quality and cross-border roaming](#). The structural case for it is the country's own: a limited terrestrial fibre build and dependence on a single submarine cable for international access, with only limited terrestrial redundancy through Senegal. No work programme, budget or timetable is published. That work took its first steering-committee session at [Banjul on 29 August 2026](#), where the four priorities were settled as infrastructure and interoperability, cyber resilience, capacity building and regulatory harmonisation, with rural electronic-government access named among them. No timetable, budget or named deliverable is attached to any of the four.

Finance

Domestic budget appropriations and expenditure

The finance ministry gave its fullest account yet of what digitalised collection has recovered. On [30 July 2026 the minister said total tax collected rose from D11 billion in 2022 to D25 billion in 2025](#), with rate rises only on gambling, alcohol and tobacco, and credited a named stack running from ASYCUDA World and digital excise stamps to fuel marking, rental tax digitalisation and electronic invoicing. He read reforms lifting collections by more than 100% as evidence of prior leakage rather than of under-taxation, and said tax to GDP moved from [9% in 2022 to 13% in 2025](#). It is an attribution by the collecting side, not an evaluation.

Four days later the revenue authority [published a 2026 target of D27.5 billion](#) — the first forward number in the series, and the first testable one. The implied step from 2025 is about a tenth, far below the run rate the attribution rests on.

ICT Infrastructure

Data Storage

President Barrow [inaugurated the National Data Centre at Abuko on 1 July 2026](#) alongside the identity system it hosts — the second data centre in ten weeks, and the first in state hands. No capacity, tier rating, operating cost or operator is stated, and the [account carried by the identity industry press](#) adds none of them. Nothing published bears on the backbone or on satellite licensing.

DPI

Data Exchange

Cross-border exchange moved further than domestic exchange did. At Saly on [16-17 July 2026 Gambian and Senegalese customs agreed a three-month roadmap](#): install GAINDE at three border posts, deploy SIGMAT for real-time transit tracking, exchange customs data by interface once GAINDE is live, replace transit agents with a Single Administrative Document and reactivate the EnCen platform.

Digital Identity and CRVS

The [National Identity Management System went live on 1 July 2026](#), issuing GAM ID cards on the spot, with nationwide enrolment from 4 August 2026. On 7 August the interior ministry [began a nationwide rollout of new ten-year biometric national identity cards, with registration opening simultaneously at six centres](#), produced with a Ghana-based supplier. No enrolment or issuance figure has been published since launch, so the system's reach is unestablished.

The rollout got the calendar the base had been missing. The government [published the phased schedule and fee structure: registration extends to Sibanor and Jarra Soma on 7 September, to Barra, Kerewan, Farafenni and Kaur on 11 September and to Janjanbureh, Basse and Fatoto on 21 September, with a first-time card at D450 waived during the rollout for holders of a valid immigration department card](#). An applicant with no passport, birth certificate or prior document must be vouched for by both the Alkalo and the Seyfo of their place of residence.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Government collection acquired a fourth channel. The Office of the Accountant General [signed a memorandum integrating the SUTURA platform into revenue collection](#), reported on 20 July 2026 — domestically built, distributed through the postal service, alongside the Yonna Wallet arrangement of March 2026. The Deputy Accountant General said several commercial banks are already integrated; the text is not held and no go-live date, volume or fee structure is given.

Registries

The country published its first unified land policy, and it is the month's clearest statement of intent about a public register. The [National Land Policy 2026-2035 mandates a digitalised National Land Administration System, a centralised Land Information System and digitised land registration](#), alongside new Certificates of Customary Ownership, and carries a costed ten-year implementation roadmap. It is a mandate rather than a build: no supplier, budget line, custodian or start date is stated for either system, and no data-protection provision for the land record is reported — in a year in which the Personal Data Protection and Privacy Act 2025 came into force.

A register the country already runs was disputed in the same week. Opposition parties put it to the electoral commission that [212,095 supplementary registrations had been announced against 179,445 records on the data distributed to them](#), a gap the commission attributed to unverified processing outputs. No reconciled figure has been published, and a presidential election is due this year.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The revenue authority said on [30 July 2026 that South African and Rwandan customs officials will study its digital excise tax stamp](#), after officials from Nigeria, Senegal and Sierra Leone; the commissioner general attached to it a [claimed 95% reduction in smuggling of excisable goods](#), a figure with no method, made by the authority whose system is being studied. The finance ministry also [named a planned Integrated Tax Administration System](#), with no procurement, vendor or timetable.

The trade ministry said on [4 August 2026](#) that a [Digital Single Window Business Registration System](#) is being [finalised](#), with no launch date.

The electoral commission's digitalisation produced its first published contest figure. At a stakeholders' forum on 7 August the chief electoral officer disclosed [1,600 objections filed against the 2026 supplementary voter roll](#), on eligibility and residency, now before Revising Court Magistrates ahead of the provisional register being merged with the 2021 Voter Register. No denominator of supplementary registrations, no outcome of the hearings and no merged register total is held.

Technology

ICT Industry

GAMTEL and YCELL [signed the Share Investment and Network Modernization Agreement on 9 July 2026](#), transferring an 80% equity stake in GAMCEL and committing GMD 6.1 billion to modernisation: nationwide 4G and 5G radio access, core upgrades, next-generation operations and billing systems, a new head office, hybrid tower power and revenue assurance. It closes a process the government [described to lawmakers in December 2025 as a D6.7 billion winning bid](#), about D800m of it a direct payment for the shares. The two figures are not reconciled in anything held.

Innovation ecosystem

Nothing published bears on artificial intelligence; the one other item is a [youth innovation showcase on 9 July 2026](#).

Capacity

Literacy

On the demand side, an [account published on 30 July 2026](#) records 400 rural women and girls trained across four regions between September 2025 and March 2026 in safe internet use, online privacy and data protection. Its implementer names unreliable internet, high data costs and unreliable electricity as the obstacles to continued practice — the only field statement in this period on what access costs a household.

Data

National statistics

Statistics had the period's clearest institutional step. The Bureau of Statistics [disseminated the fifth labour force survey in late July 2026](#) with a [companion volume comparing the 2023, 2025 and 2026 rounds](#) — participation at 54.5% against 43.6% in 2023, unemployment at 6.2% against 7.6%. The [findings report puts the agriculture share of employment at 17.8%](#), which reflects the 19th ICLS standard excluding own-use food production and is not comparable with earlier rounds. The Central Bank had [convened producers and users two days earlier](#), naming data gaps, inconsistency and inaccessibility as the constraints.

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